

Still Interim

Auditing Seven Extensions to a Library Equipment Desk's Never-Confirmed Review Date

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The problem

The Library's Equipment Loan Service reverted from self-service kiosk return to a staffed sign-off desk in March 2024, pending a formal service review. What becomes of a "pending" arrangement once the problem it was meant to test has already gone away?

Research questions

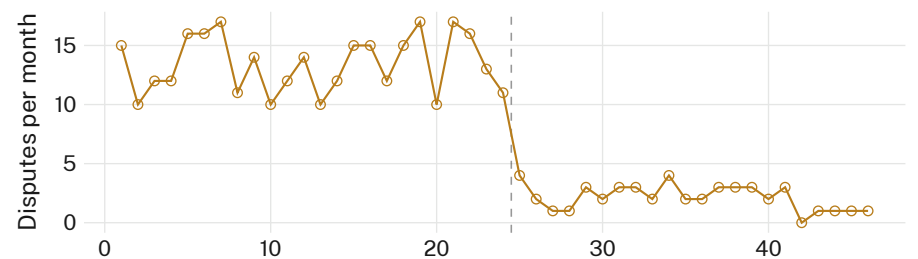
- How many times has the desk's review date been extended since the March 2024 changeover
- Whether the staffed desk's dispute rate still justifies treating the arrangement as provisional
- Whether extension timing tracks dispute data or the Library Services Committee's own meeting calendar

Approach

- 7 extension memos and 22 months of Library Services Committee minutes, March 2024–December 2025
- Return-condition dispute counts, staffed period vs. a 24-month kiosk-era baseline
- Each memo's stated review trigger coded against the dispute threshold it cites

Findings

The staffed desk cut monthly disputes from a kiosk-era mean of 13.4 to 2.1 within the first quarter, and the rate has not exceeded 3 disputes a month since April 2024. The arrangement remains classified interim.



Monthly equipment-loan return-condition disputes, March 2022–December 2025 (dashed line marks the March 2024 changeover). Disputes have held under 3 a month for nineteen of the staffed desk's twenty-two months in operation; its review date has been extended seven times regardless.

Implications

Each extension memo repeats the last one's wording almost verbatim — insufficient operational data to warrant a permanent determination — on a service whose own incident log says otherwise. The desk works; what's unresolved is only its status, and the status is what keeps getting minuted: a determination would close the item, while an extension merely defers it to the next agenda, which is the cheaper motion to carry. Next: whether an interim arrangement needs an expiry mechanism of its own, rather than a renewable one.

Selected references

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Dispute counts drawn from the Equipment Loan Service's own incident log; no borrower identities retained.

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